not been forced to retire, if he had been able to play in the three-Test series against England, he would have (a) played his 150th Test at Lord's, and become the first wicketkeeper to reach that milestone, (b) almost certainly have scored the 56 more runs he needed to become the highest run-scorer among wicketkeepers in Tests, passing Gilchrist's record, and (c) completed the two dismissals he required to reach 1 000 in his international career and so become the first to reach that mark.

In fact, Bouch maintains he did reach 1 000 dismissals for South Africa, even if his catches and stumpings add up to 998. 'People sometimes forget the two Test wickets I took as a bowler,' he says.

In the end, however, the records and statistics don't count for much. Mark Boucher's legacy confirms him as one of the greatest wicketkeepers of all time and as an incredible human being; and it is completely in character that he should now be directing so much time and energy to preserving the rhino population.

Smith, Kallis and Boucher were the three pillars.

I respected them and admired them. But more than anything, I wanted to impress them and wanted them to like me.

So when they trained hard in the nets, I trained hard and was the last to leave the practice. When they said it was time to relax, get out of the hotel and have a few drinks, I would follow them out of the hotel and have a few drinks and would usually be the last to leave the bar.

In effect, they were the leaders of the Proteas club and I wanted to become a member.

It's true some resented the trio's continuing dominance and success, and it's also true that, perhaps eager to create a headline or sell a book, some have claimed they operated as a clique, looking after their own interests ahead of the team.

This is nonsense. As the saying goes, tall trees catch the most wind, and as far as I am concerned, Smith, Kallis and Boucher deserve nothing